



NICK'S

MEAL PICKER COOKBOOK

Choose 2-5 meals. I build the shopping list and cook with you.

30 family meals plus 8 easy cookies and desserts - designed to grow over time

Designed for two adults and two children. Vegetables remain optional for the kids, and every meal includes a simple kid plate.

How the picker works

1. Scroll through the recipe cards. 2. Choose any 2-5 meal codes and an optional D-code dessert. 3. Send the codes to me in this chat. 4. I will create one combined Wednesday shopping list, remove duplicate ingredients, estimate the total, separate optional upgrades and give you a storage/thaw plan.

Example

Send: **B2, C1, P1 and F5**. I will return the exact quantities to buy for French toast, chicken tacos, sheet-pan pork chops and personal pizzas.

During cooking

Say: **I'm cooking C1. Walk me through it.** I will give one step at a time, coordinate sides, answer questions and help with timers.

Budget

\$	Budget-friendly	Best for keeping 4-5 meals inside the regular budget.
\$\$	Moderate	Usually comfortable when mixed with \$ meals.
\$\$\$	Upgrade	Steak meal; consider the optional \$50.

Picking 2-3 meals normally fits the core plan. For 4-5 meals, choose mostly \$ meals or use some of the optional \$50. You never have to spend the extra amount.

Code guide

B = Breakfast for Dinner | C = Chicken | PA = Pasta | P = Pork | S = Steak | F = Family Favorites | D = Cookies & Desserts

Your kitchen

You have a full kitchen, a decent-size air fryer and an outdoor Blackstone. Recipes that benefit from those appliances include an alternate equipment note on the full recipe page. Standard oven-and-stove directions remain the default while you learn.

Best first pan upgrade

A 12-inch tri-ply stainless-steel skillet is the most useful indoor addition because the Blackstone already covers large-surface searing. Stainless works for chicken, pork, steak, pan sauces and acidic tomato or lemon ingredients. Add an inexpensive 12-inch cast-iron skillet later if you want stronger heat retention and do not mind the weight and seasoning care.



B1

Breakfast for
Dinner

Pancakes, Eggs & Bacon

Prep 10 min | Cook 25 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Sheet pan, mixing bowl, skillet

INGREDIENTS

- Pancake mix for 8-10 pancakes
- 8 eggs
- 8 strips bacon
- Milk or water required by mix
- Fruit and syrup

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Heat oven to 400 F. Put bacon on a foil-lined sheet and bake 15-20 minutes.
- 2 Prepare pancake batter as the package directs. Heat a lightly oiled skillet over medium.
- 3 Cook small pancakes; flip when bubbles form and the edges look dry.
- 4 Whisk eggs and scramble in a buttered skillet over medium-low until just set.

KID PLATE

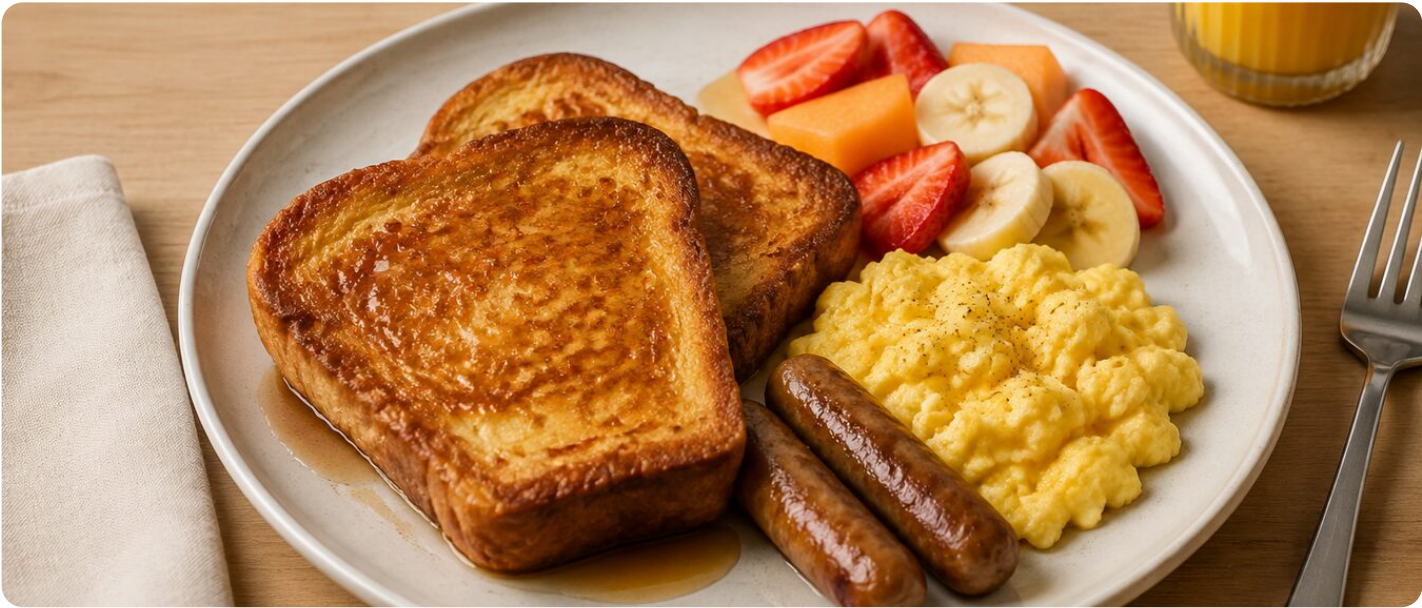
Serve everything separately; fruit can replace anything refused.

LEFTOVERS

Cool extra pancakes and refrigerate for a quick snack or breakfast.

EQUIPMENT

Air fryer: cook bacon at 375 F for about 8-12 minutes; check early.



B2

Breakfast for
Dinner

French Toast, Eggs & Sausage

Prep 10 min | Cook 25 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Shallow bowl, 2 skillets

INGREDIENTS

- 8 sturdy bread slices
- 12 eggs
- 1/2 cup milk
- 1/2 tsp cinnamon
- Breakfast sausage
- Fruit and syrup

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Cook sausage according to its package until fully cooked; keep warm.
- 2 Whisk 6 eggs with milk and cinnamon in a shallow dish.
- 3 Dip bread briefly on both sides. Cook in a buttered skillet over medium, 2-3 minutes per side.
- 4 Scramble remaining eggs over medium-low heat.

KID PLATE

Cut French toast into strips and put syrup in a dipping cup.

LEFTOVERS

Reheat extra French toast in a toaster or skillet.



B3

Breakfast for
Dinner

Breakfast Burritos

Prep 15 min | Cook 25 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$\$

PREP & TOOLS

2 skillets, knife, cutting board

INGREDIENTS

- 10 flour tortillas
- 10 eggs
- 1 lb breakfast sausage
- 1 lb potatoes, small dice
- 2 cups shredded cheese
- Fruit

DIRECTIONS

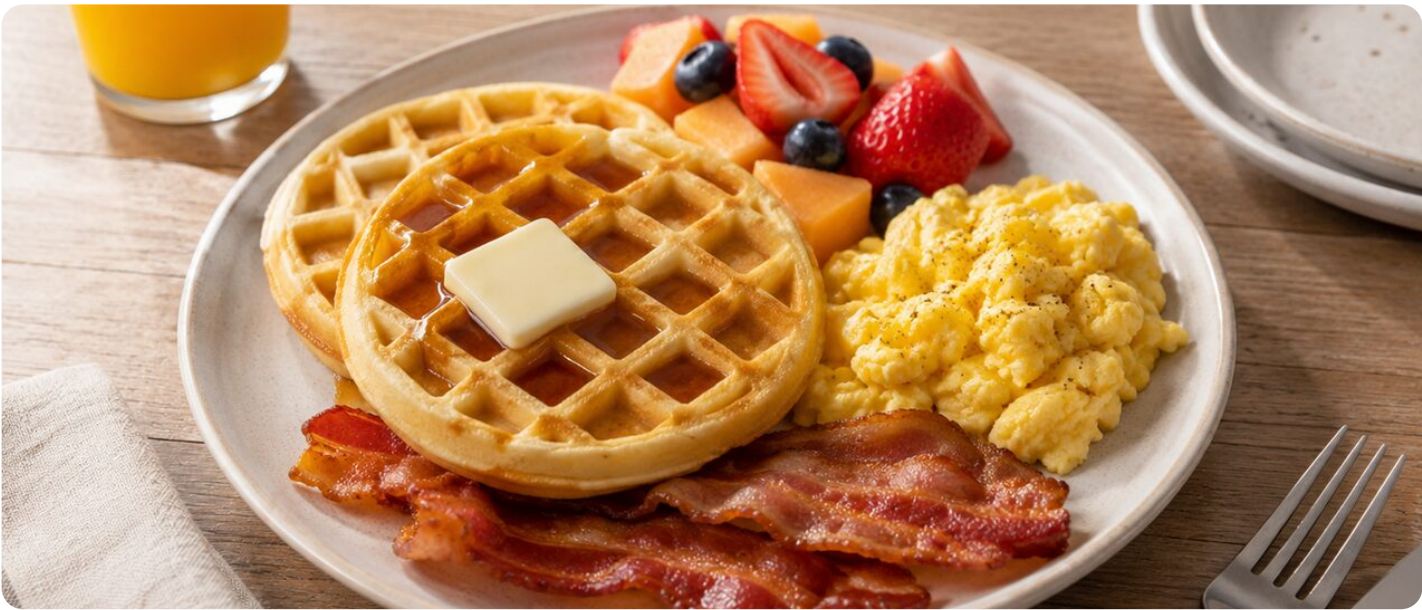
- 1 Brown sausage in a skillet until fully cooked; move to a plate.
- 2 Add a little oil and cook diced potatoes, covered, 12-15 minutes; stir every few minutes.
- 3 Scramble eggs in a second skillet over medium-low.
- 4 Warm tortillas and fill with eggs, potatoes, sausage and cheese.

KID PLATE

Serve the fillings as separate piles with a tortilla.

LEFTOVERS

Wrap extra burritos in foil and refrigerate up to 3 days.



B4

Breakfast for
Dinner

Waffles, Eggs & Bacon

Prep 10 min | Cook 25 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Waffle iron, sheet pan, skillet

INGREDIENTS

- Waffle mix for 8 waffles
- 8 eggs
- 8 strips bacon
- Milk or water required by mix
- Fruit and syrup

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Heat oven to 400 F and bake bacon on a lined sheet for 15-20 minutes.
- 2 Preheat waffle iron and prepare batter as the mix directs.
- 3 Cook waffles using the amount recommended for your machine.
- 4 Scramble eggs over medium-low heat and serve with fruit.

KID PLATE

Cut waffles into strips; keep foods separate.

LEFTOVERS

Freeze cooled waffles with parchment between them and toast later.

EQUIPMENT

Air fryer: cook bacon at 375 F for about 8-12 minutes; check early.



C1

Chicken Tacos

Chicken

Prep 10 min | Cook 20 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Knife, cutting board, large skillet

INGREDIENTS

- 1.5-2 lb boneless chicken
- 8-10 flour tortillas
- 1/2 packet taco seasoning
- 2 cups shredded cheese
- Mild salsa
- Lettuce

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Cut chicken into bite-size pieces and wash hands and the board.
- 2 Heat 1 tbsp oil in a skillet over medium-high. Add chicken and seasoning.
- 3 Cook 8-12 minutes, stirring occasionally, until chicken reaches 165 F.
- 4 Warm tortillas under a damp paper towel for 30 seconds and assemble at the table.

KID PLATE

Plain chicken, tortilla and cheese; cheese quesadilla as backup.

LEFTOVERS

Use leftover chicken in quesadillas or lunch wraps.

EQUIPMENT

Blackstone: cook seasoned chicken pieces over medium-high heat, stirring, to 165 F.



C2

Chicken

Lemon-Garlic Chicken, Rice & Broccoli

Prep 10 min | Cook 30 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Sheet pan, saucepan

INGREDIENTS

- 2 lb boneless chicken thighs
- 1.5 cups dry rice
- 1 large broccoli crown or frozen florets
- 1 lemon
- Oil, salt and garlic powder

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Heat oven to 425 F. Start rice according to its package.
- 2 Coat chicken lightly with oil, salt and garlic powder; place on a lined sheet.
- 3 Bake 20-25 minutes until chicken reaches 165 F.
- 4 Steam broccoli 5-7 minutes. Squeeze lemon over the adult portions.

KID PLATE

Keep chicken plain and serve rice separately.

LEFTOVERS

Chop leftover chicken for rice bowls or sandwiches.

EQUIPMENT

Air fryer: cook chicken thighs at 380 F for about 16-20 minutes to 165 F.



C3

Chicken

Creamy Chicken Penne

Prep 10 min | Cook 25 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$\$

PREP & TOOLS

Large pot, skillet, colander

INGREDIENTS

- 1.5 lb chicken, bite-size
- 1 lb penne
- 1 jar Alfredo sauce
- Broccoli, optional
- Parmesan, optional

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Boil penne according to the package; add broccoli during the last 3 minutes if using.
- 2 Cook chicken in an oiled skillet over medium-high for 8-12 minutes to 165 F.
- 3 Drain pasta and return it to the pot with chicken and Alfredo sauce.
- 4 Warm over low heat 3-5 minutes. Thin with a splash of milk if needed.

KID PLATE

Save plain penne and chicken before adding sauce.

LEFTOVERS

Add a little milk when reheating so the sauce loosens.



C4

Chicken

Easy Chicken Parmesan

Prep 15 min | Cook 30 min | Serves 4 | Learning | \$\$

PREP & TOOLS

Sheet pan, 2 shallow bowls, pot

INGREDIENTS

- 4 thin chicken cutlets
- 1 egg
- 1 cup seasoned breadcrumbs
- 1 lb spaghetti
- 1 jar marinara
- 1.5 cups mozzarella

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Heat oven to 425 F. Dip chicken in beaten egg, then coat with breadcrumbs.
- 2 Place on an oiled sheet and bake 15 minutes; flip and bake 5-10 minutes more to 165 F.
- 3 Boil spaghetti. Warm marinara in a small pan or microwave-safe bowl.
- 4 Top chicken with sauce and cheese; return to oven 3-5 minutes until melted.

KID PLATE

Reserve one lightly breaded cutlet, plain noodles and sauce on the side.

LEFTOVERS

Slice leftover chicken for a sandwich.

EQUIPMENT

Air fryer: cook breaded cutlets at 390 F for about 10-14 minutes to 165 F; add sauce and cheese at the end.



PA1

Pasta

Spaghetti with Meat Sauce

Prep 10 min | Cook 20 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Large pot, skillet, colander

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb spaghetti
- 1 lb ground beef or turkey
- 1 jar marinara
- 1/2 onion, optional
- Bread and butter, optional

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Bring a large pot of water to a boil.
- 2 Brown meat over medium-high, breaking it apart, until it reaches 160 F; drain grease.
- 3 Add marinara and simmer on low for 10 minutes.
- 4 Cook and drain spaghetti according to the box; save some plain noodles before serving.

KID PLATE

Buttered noodles with sauce and meat offered separately.

LEFTOVERS

Refrigerate sauce and pasta separately for better leftovers.



PA2

Pasta

Easy Baked Ziti

Prep 15 min | Cook 30 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$\$

PREP & TOOLS

Large pot, skillet, 9x13 dish

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb ziti
- 1 lb ground beef or turkey
- 1 jar marinara
- 15 oz ricotta or cottage cheese
- 2 cups mozzarella

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Heat oven to 375 F. Boil ziti 2 minutes less than the box says; drain.
- 2 Brown meat to 160 F, drain, and stir in marinara.
- 3 Mix pasta, meat sauce and ricotta in a greased baking dish.
- 4 Top with mozzarella and bake 20-25 minutes until bubbling.

KID PLATE

Reserve plain pasta and meat before mixing; add cheese if wanted.

LEFTOVERS

Portion and freeze extra ziti after it cools.



PA3

Pasta

Sausage Penne Marinara

Prep 10 min | Cook 20 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Large pot, skillet, colander

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb mild Italian sausage
- 1 lb penne
- 1 jar marinara
- Parmesan or mozzarella

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Boil penne according to the package.
- 2 Remove sausage from casings if needed. Brown it over medium-high, breaking it apart, to 160 F.
- 3 Drain grease, add marinara and simmer 8-10 minutes.
- 4 Save plain pasta, then combine the rest or spoon sauce over each plate.

KID PLATE

Plain pasta with cheese; sausage offered separately.

LEFTOVERS

Use leftovers for lunch or freeze in single portions.



PA4

Pasta

Cheeseburger Pasta

Prep 10 min | Cook 25 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Large skillet with lid, spoon

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb ground beef
- 12 oz elbow macaroni
- 3 cups beef broth
- 1 cup milk
- 2 cups shredded cheddar
- 2 tbsp ketchup

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Brown beef over medium-high to 160 F; drain excess grease.
- 2 Stir in dry macaroni, broth and ketchup. Bring to a gentle boil.
- 3 Cover, lower heat and simmer 10-12 minutes, stirring twice, until pasta is tender.
- 4 Stir in milk and cheddar over low heat until creamy.

KID PLATE

Remove some cooked beef and pasta before adding all the sauce if needed.

LEFTOVERS

Reheat slowly with a splash of milk.



PA5

Pasta

Spaghetti & Meatballs

Prep 15 min | Cook 30 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Mixing bowl, sheet pan, large pot

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb ground beef
- 1 egg
- 1/3 cup breadcrumbs
- 1/4 cup Parmesan
- 1 lb spaghetti
- 1 jar marinara

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Heat oven to 425 F. Gently mix beef, egg, breadcrumbs, Parmesan, 1/2 tsp salt and a little pepper.
- 2 Form about 16 meatballs and place on a lined sheet. Bake 12-16 minutes until centers reach 160 F.
- 3 Boil spaghetti according to the box and warm marinara in a saucepan.
- 4 Add cooked meatballs to the sauce and serve over pasta.

KID PLATE

Plain noodles, one cut-up meatball and sauce on the side.

LEFTOVERS

Freeze cooled meatballs in sauce for another meal.



PA6

Pasta

Chicken Pesto Rotini

Prep 10 min | Cook 25 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$\$

PREP & TOOLS

Large pot, skillet, colander

INGREDIENTS

- 1.5 lb chicken, bite-size
- 1 lb rotini
- 6-8 oz prepared pesto
- Cherry tomatoes, optional
- Parmesan

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Boil rotini according to the package; save 1/2 cup pasta water before draining.
- 2 Cook chicken in an oiled skillet over medium-high for 8-12 minutes to 165 F.
- 3 Return pasta to the pot and stir in pesto, chicken and a small splash of pasta water.
- 4 Add halved tomatoes for adults and finish with Parmesan.

KID PLATE

Save plain rotini and chicken before adding pesto.

LEFTOVERS

Serve cold or warm as a next-day pasta lunch.



PA7

Pasta

Cheesy Ravioli Bake

Prep 10 min | Cook 35 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$\$

PREP & TOOLS

9x13 baking dish, foil

INGREDIENTS

- About 36 oz refrigerated cheese ravioli
- 1 jar marinara
- 2 cups shredded mozzarella
- 1/2 cup Parmesan

DIRECTIONS

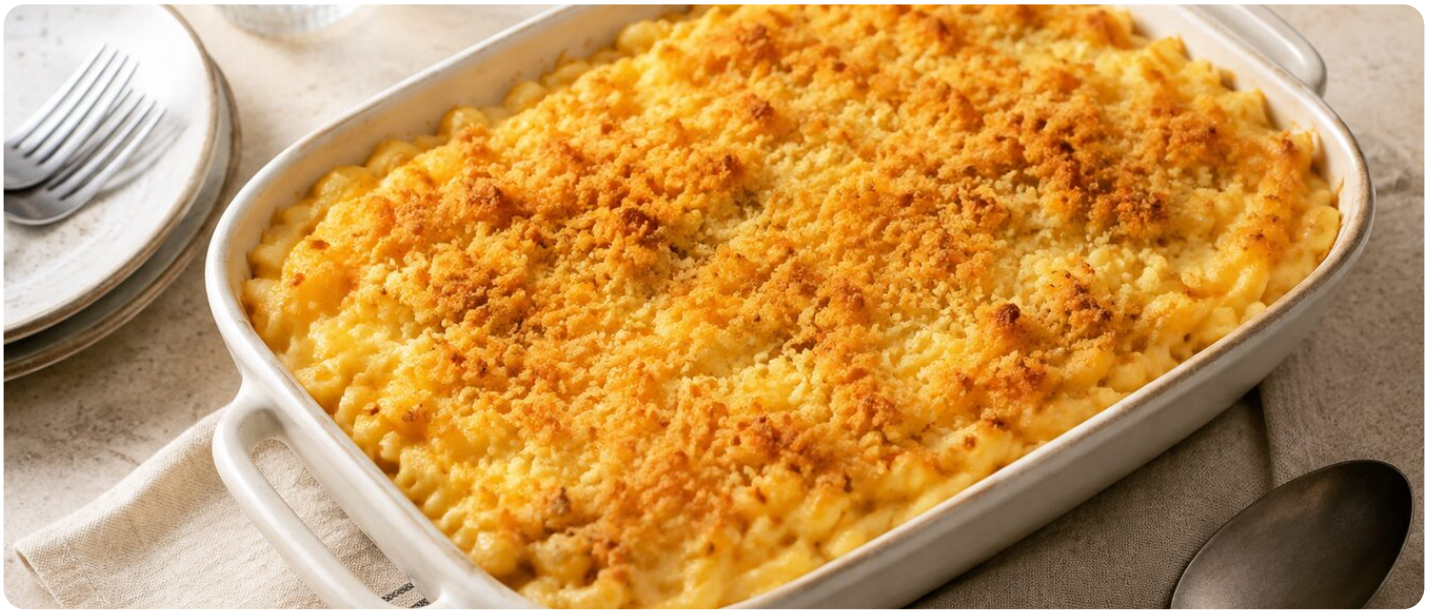
- 1 Heat oven to 375 F and spread a thin layer of sauce in a greased baking dish.
- 2 Layer half the ravioli, half the remaining sauce and half the mozzarella; repeat.
- 3 Cover with foil and bake 25 minutes.
- 4 Uncover, add Parmesan and bake 10 more minutes until bubbling and hot throughout.

KID PLATE

Keep a few ravioli lightly sauced and serve separately.

LEFTOVERS

Portion and freeze the cooled bake.



PA8

Pasta

Baked Mac & Cheese

Prep 15 min | Cook 30 min | Serves 4 | Learning | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Large pot, saucepan, whisk, baking dish

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb elbow macaroni
- 4 tbsp butter
- 1/4 cup flour
- 3 cups milk
- 3 cups shredded cheddar
- 1/2 cup breadcrumbs, optional

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Heat oven to 375 F. Boil macaroni 2 minutes less than the box directs; drain.
- 2 Melt butter in a saucepan over medium. Whisk in flour for 1 minute, then slowly whisk in milk.
- 3 Cook 4-6 minutes until slightly thick. Lower heat and stir in cheddar until smooth.
- 4 Combine sauce and pasta in a greased dish, add breadcrumbs if using, and bake 15-20 minutes.

KID PLATE

Serve plain and keep the breadcrumb topping light or omit it.

LEFTOVERS

Reheat with a splash of milk.



PA9

Pasta

Chicken-Bacon Ranch Penne

Prep 15 min | Cook 25 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$\$

PREP & TOOLS

Large pot, skillet, colander

INGREDIENTS

- 1.5 lb chicken, bite-size
- 1 lb penne
- 8 oz cream cheese
- 1 cup milk
- 1 ranch seasoning packet
- 1/2 cup cooked bacon pieces
- Broccoli, optional

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Boil penne; add broccoli for the final 3 minutes if using, then drain.
- 2 Cook chicken in an oiled skillet over medium-high for 8-12 minutes to 165 F.
- 3 Lower heat. Add cream cheese, milk and half the ranch seasoning; stir until smooth.
- 4 Add pasta, chicken and bacon. Taste before adding more ranch seasoning.

KID PLATE

Save plain penne and chicken before adding sauce.

LEFTOVERS

Reheat slowly with extra milk.



PA10

Pasta

Easy Skillet Lasagna

Prep 15 min | Cook 30 min | Serves 4 | Learning | \$\$

PREP & TOOLS

Deep skillet with lid, spoon

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb ground beef
- 8 oven-ready lasagna noodles, broken
- 1 jar marinara
- 2 cups water
- 1 cup ricotta or cottage cheese
- 1.5 cups mozzarella

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Brown beef in a deep skillet over medium-high to 160 F; drain grease.
- 2 Stir in marinara, water and broken noodles. Bring to a gentle boil.
- 3 Cover, lower heat and simmer 18-22 minutes, stirring every 5 minutes, until noodles are tender.
- 4 Dollop ricotta over the top, add mozzarella, cover and cook 3-5 minutes until melted.

KID PLATE

Save some cooked beef and tender noodle pieces before adding all the cheese.

LEFTOVERS

Refrigerate in individual portions for easy lunches.



P1

Pork

Sheet-Pan Pork Chops

Prep 10 min | Cook 30 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$\$

PREP & TOOLS

Knife, cutting board, sheet pan

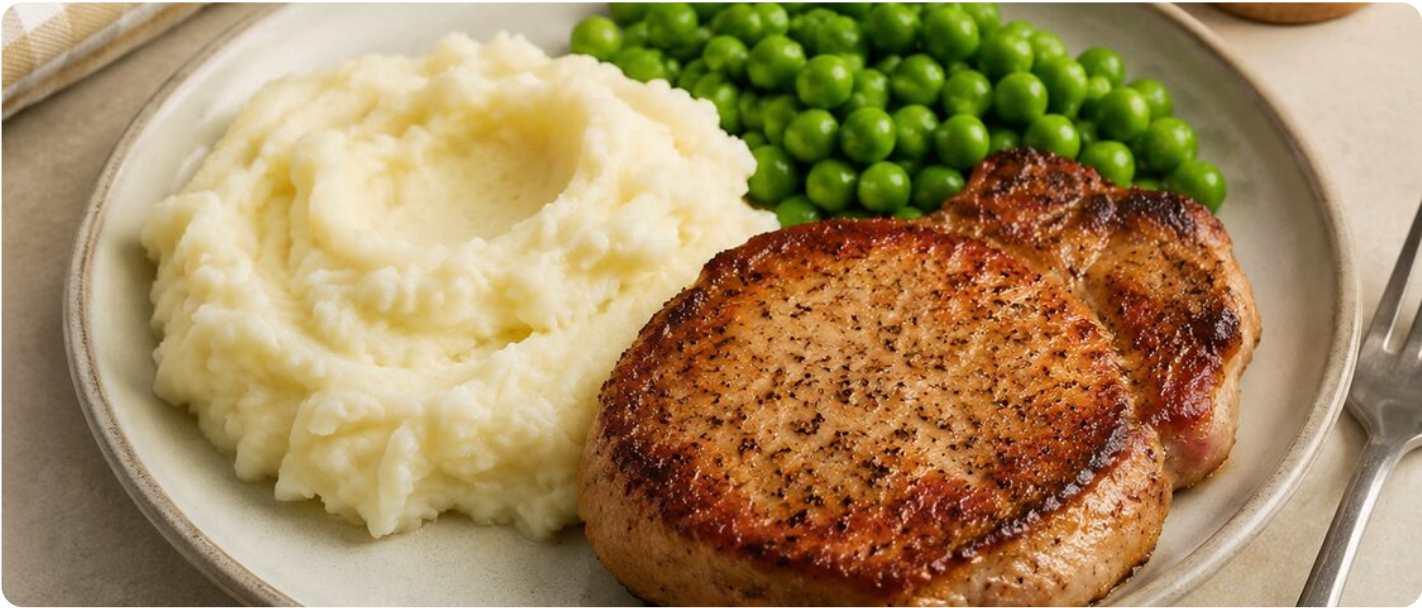
INGREDIENTS

- 4 pork chops
- 3 lb potatoes
- Green beans or broccoli
- Oil, salt, pepper and garlic powder

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Heat oven to 425 F. Cut potatoes into 1-inch pieces and toss with oil and seasoning.
- 2 Roast potatoes 15 minutes, then push them to one side.
- 3 Add seasoned pork chops and vegetables; roast 15-20 minutes more.
- 4 Remove pork at 145 F and rest 3 minutes.

KID PLATE	Sliced plain pork, potatoes and fruit if vegetables are skipped.
LEFTOVERS	Dice leftover pork for rice or quesadillas.
EQUIPMENT	Air fryer: cook chops at 380 F for about 10-14 minutes to 145 F; rest 3 minutes.



P2

Pork

Pork Chops & Mashed Potatoes

Prep 15 min | Cook 30 min | Serves 4 | Learning | \$\$

PREP & TOOLS

Large pot, skillet, masher

INGREDIENTS

- 4 pork chops
- 3 lb potatoes
- Milk and butter
- Frozen peas or green beans
- Salt and pepper

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Cut potatoes into chunks, cover with cold salted water and boil 15-20 minutes.
- 2 Season pork. Cook in an oiled skillet over medium-high about 4-6 minutes per side to 145 F; rest 3 minutes.
- 3 Drain potatoes and mash with butter and small splashes of milk.
- 4 Microwave or steam vegetables according to the package.

KID PLATE

Sliced plain pork and mashed potatoes; vegetable optional.

LEFTOVERS

Make a pork-and-potato bowl for lunch.

EQUIPMENT

Blackstone: sear chops over medium-high heat to 145 F; rest 3 minutes.



P3

Pork

Crispy Oven Pork Chops

Prep 15 min | Cook 30 min | Serves 4 | Learning | \$\$

PREP & TOOLS

Sheet pan, 2 shallow bowls

INGREDIENTS

- 4 thin pork chops
- 1 egg
- 1 cup seasoned breadcrumbs
- 2 lb potatoes
- Carrots
- Oil

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Heat oven to 425 F. Cut potatoes and carrots; oil and season them on a sheet pan.
- 2 Whisk egg in one bowl and put breadcrumbs in another. Dip pork in egg, then crumbs.
- 3 Add pork to the pan. Roast 20-25 minutes, turning pork once.
- 4 Remove pork at 145 F and rest 3 minutes.

KID PLATE

Use a light crumb coating and serve everything separately.

LEFTOVERS

Slice leftovers for sandwiches.

EQUIPMENT

Air fryer: cook breaded chops at 390 F for about 10-14 minutes to 145 F; rest 3 minutes.



P4

Pork

Honey-Garlic Pork Tenderloin

Prep 15 min | Cook 25 min | Serves 4 | Learning | \$\$

PREP & TOOLS

Knife, skillet, saucepan

INGREDIENTS

- 1.5 lb pork tenderloin
- 1.5 cups dry rice
- Broccoli
- 3 tbsp honey
- 2 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 tsp garlic powder

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Start rice according to its package. Slice pork into 1-inch medallions.
- 2 Mix honey, soy sauce, garlic powder and 2 tbsp water.
- 3 Sear pork in an oiled skillet over medium-high for 3-4 minutes per side to 145 F; rest 3 minutes.
- 4 Lower heat, add sauce and simmer 1-2 minutes. Steam broccoli separately.

KID PLATE

Keep several pork pieces plain before adding sauce.

LEFTOVERS

Use leftover pork and rice for a quick bowl.

EQUIPMENT

Blackstone: sear pork medallions over medium-high heat; keep the honey sauce in a small pan indoors.



S1

Steak & Beef

Simple Sirloin Steak Dinner

Prep 10 min | Cook 30 min | Serves 4 | Learning | \$\$\$

PREP & TOOLS

Heavy skillet, sheet pan, thermometer

INGREDIENTS

- 1.5-2 lb sirloin steak, about 1 inch thick
- 2 lb potatoes
- Green beans
- Oil, butter, salt and pepper

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Heat oven to 425 F. Roast oiled, seasoned potato pieces for 25-30 minutes.
- 2 Pat steak dry and season. Heat a heavy skillet over medium-high and add a little oil.
- 3 Cook steak about 4-6 minutes per side; remove at 145 F and rest 3 minutes.
- 4 Steam green beans 5-7 minutes and finish with butter. Slice steak across the grain.

KID PLATE

Serve thin steak slices with potatoes and fruit or beans.

LEFTOVERS

Use leftover steak in eggs, tacos or sandwiches.

EQUIPMENT

Blackstone: ideal option. Sear steak over medium-high heat, remove at 145 F and rest 3 minutes.



S2

Steak Fajitas

Steak & Beef

Prep 15 min | Cook 20 min | Serves 4 | Learning | \$\$\$

PREP & TOOLS

Knife, cutting board, large skillet

INGREDIENTS

- 1.5 lb sirloin steak, thinly sliced
- 2 bell peppers
- 1 onion
- Fajita seasoning
- 8-10 tortillas
- Cheese

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Cook sliced peppers and onion in 1 tbsp oil over medium-high for 6-8 minutes; move to a plate.
- 2 Cook steak with seasoning in the same skillet for 3-5 minutes, stirring, to desired doneness.
- 3 Return vegetables for the final minute or keep them separate.
- 4 Warm tortillas and serve with cheese.

KID PLATE

Plain steak strips, tortilla and cheese; vegetables stay separate.

LEFTOVERS

Turn leftovers into quesadillas.

EQUIPMENT

Blackstone: cook peppers and onion first, then steak; keep kid portions separate.



F1

Family
Favorites

Classic Beef Tacos

Prep 10 min | Cook 15 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Large skillet, spoon

INGREDIENTS

- 1.25 lb ground beef
- 1 packet mild taco seasoning
- 8-10 tortillas
- 2 cups shredded cheese
- Mild salsa
- Lettuce

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Brown beef over medium-high, breaking it apart, until it reaches 160 F.
- 2 Drain grease. Add seasoning and the water listed on the packet.
- 3 Simmer 3-5 minutes until the liquid reduces.
- 4 Warm tortillas and let everyone build their own tacos.

KID PLATE	Plain beef, tortilla and cheese; remove their beef before adding all seasoning if needed.
LEFTOVERS	Use leftover taco meat in quesadillas or baked potatoes.
EQUIPMENT	Blackstone: brown taco meat, drain carefully and finish with seasoning.



F2

Family
Favorites

Cheeseburgers & Oven Fries

Prep 15 min | Cook 30 min | Serves 4 | Learning | \$\$

PREP & TOOLS

Sheet pan, skillet or grill pan

INGREDIENTS

- 1.5 lb ground beef
- 4 burger buns
- 4 cheese slices
- 2 lb russet potatoes
- Optional lettuce, tomato and pickles
- Oil, salt and pepper

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Heat oven to 425 F. Cut potatoes into wedges, toss with oil and salt, and roast 25-35 minutes.
- 2 Form beef gently into 4 equal patties; press a small dent in each center.
- 3 Cook in a hot skillet 4-5 minutes per side to 160 F. Add cheese during the last minute.
- 4 Toast buns briefly and assemble.

KID PLATE

Plain cheeseburger with toppings on the side.

LEFTOVERS

Crumble leftover burger into eggs or pasta.

EQUIPMENT

Blackstone: ideal option for burgers; cook the centers to 160 F.



F3

Family
Favorites

Easy Meatloaf & Roasted Vegetables

Prep 10 min | Cook 40 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Mixing bowl, sheet pan

INGREDIENTS

- 1.5 lb ground beef or turkey
- 1 egg
- 1/2 cup breadcrumbs
- 1/3 cup ketchup
- 2 lb potatoes
- Carrots

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Heat oven to 400 F. Mix meat, egg, breadcrumbs, half the ketchup, 1 tsp salt and a little pepper.
- 2 Shape into a loaf on one side of a lined sheet; spread remaining ketchup on top.
- 3 Add small potato and carrot pieces tossed with oil to the other side.
- 4 Bake 35-45 minutes until the center reaches 160 F.

KID PLATE

Offer an inside slice with less ketchup, potatoes and fruit.

LEFTOVERS

Make meatloaf sandwiches the next day.



F4

Family
Favorites

Mild Family Chili

Prep 15 min | Cook 30 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Large pot, spoon

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb ground beef or turkey
- 1 can kidney beans, drained
- 1 can black beans, drained
- 1 large can crushed tomatoes
- 1 mild chili seasoning packet
- Cheddar and cornbread, optional

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Brown meat in a large pot over medium-high to 160 F; drain grease.
- 2 Add beans, tomatoes, seasoning and 1/2 cup water.
- 3 Bring to a gentle boil, then lower heat and simmer uncovered 20 minutes.
- 4 Serve with cheese and cornbread.

KID PLATE

Set aside plain cooked meat before seasoning; offer cheese and cornbread.

LEFTOVERS

Chili freezes well in meal-size containers.



F5

Family
Favorites

Personal Pizzas

Prep 15 min | Cook 15 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$\$

PREP & TOOLS

2 sheet pans

INGREDIENTS

- 4 naan breads or personal pizza crusts
- 1 jar pizza sauce
- 3 cups mozzarella
- Pepperoni
- Optional mushrooms, peppers or olives

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Heat oven to 425 F and place crusts on lined sheet pans.
- 2 Spread each with a thin layer of sauce, leaving a small border.
- 3 Add cheese and let everyone choose toppings.
- 4 Bake 10-14 minutes until cheese bubbles and crust edges brown.

KID PLATE

Let each child build a simple cheese or pepperoni pizza.

LEFTOVERS

Refrigerate slices and reheat in the oven or air fryer.

EQUIPMENT

Air fryer: cook personal pizzas in batches at about 375 F until the cheese bubbles and the crust is crisp.



F6

Family
Favorites

Baked Potato Bar

Prep 10 min | Cook 50 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Sheet pan, small bowls

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large russet potatoes
- 2 cups shredded cheddar
- Cooked bacon pieces
- Broccoli
- Sour cream
- Optional leftover taco meat or chicken

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Heat oven to 425 F. Scrub potatoes, dry, pierce with a fork and rub lightly with oil and salt.
- 2 Bake directly on a sheet pan for 45-60 minutes until easily pierced.
- 3 Steam broccoli and warm any meat topping.
- 4 Split potatoes, fluff the centers and place toppings in separate bowls.

KID PLATE	Plain potato with butter and cheese; toppings stay optional.
LEFTOVERS	Dice leftover potatoes for breakfast or turn them into potato skins.
EQUIPMENT	Air fryer: cook scrubbed, pierced potatoes at 400 F for about 35-50 minutes, depending on size.



D1

Cookies &
Desserts

Chocolate Chip Cookies

Prep 20 min | Cook 10 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

2 bowls, mixer or sturdy spoon, sheet pans

INGREDIENTS

- 2 1/4 cups flour
- 1 tsp baking soda
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 cup softened butter
- 3/4 cup sugar
- 3/4 cup brown sugar
- 2 eggs
- 2 tsp vanilla
- 2 cups chocolate chips

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Heat oven to 375 F. Whisk flour, baking soda and salt in one bowl.
- 2 Beat butter with both sugars until creamy. Beat in eggs one at a time, then vanilla.
- 3 Stir in the dry mixture, then chocolate chips. Scoop rounded tablespoons onto ungreased sheets.
- 4 Bake 9-11 minutes until edges are golden. Cool 2 minutes on the pan, then move to a rack.

KID HELPER

Cooper and Leni can measure chips or scoop dough with supervision.

LEFTOVERS

Keep airtight 4 days or freeze baked cookies or dough balls.



D2

Cookies &
Desserts

Four-Ingredient Peanut Butter Cookies

Prep 10 min | Cook 10 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Mixing bowl, fork, sheet pan

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup creamy peanut butter
- 1 cup sugar
- 1 large egg
- 1 tsp vanilla

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Heat oven to 350 F and line a sheet pan with parchment.
- 2 Mix peanut butter, sugar, egg and vanilla until smooth.
- 3 Roll tablespoon-size balls, place 2 inches apart and flatten with a fork in a crosshatch.
- 4 Bake 8-10 minutes. Let cool on the pan for 5 minutes before moving.

KID HELPER

The kids can roll dough and make the fork marks. Check for peanut allergies before sharing.

LEFTOVERS

Store airtight up to 4 days.



D3

Cookies & Desserts

Easy Sugar Cookies

Prep 15 min | Cook 10 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

2 bowls, mixer or sturdy spoon, sheet pans

INGREDIENTS

- 2 3/4 cups flour
- 1 tsp baking soda
- 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1 cup softened butter
- 1 1/2 cups sugar
- 1 egg
- 1 tsp vanilla
- Extra sugar for rolling

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Heat oven to 375 F. Whisk flour, baking soda and baking powder.
- 2 Beat butter and sugar until creamy. Beat in egg and vanilla.
- 3 Stir in dry ingredients. Roll tablespoon-size balls and lightly roll them in extra sugar.
- 4 Bake 8-10 minutes until edges are barely golden; cool on the pan 2 minutes.

KID HELPER

The kids can roll dough balls in sugar.

LEFTOVERS

Store airtight 4 days or freeze dough balls.



D4

Cookies &
Desserts

No-Bake Chocolate Oatmeal Cookies

Prep 10 min | Cook 10 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Saucepan, spoon, parchment

INGREDIENTS

- 1/2 cup butter
- 2 cups sugar
- 1/2 cup milk
- 1/4 cup cocoa powder
- 1/2 cup peanut butter
- 3 cups quick oats
- 1 tsp vanilla

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Lay out parchment before starting. Combine butter, sugar, milk and cocoa in a saucepan.
- 2 Bring to a full rolling boil over medium heat and boil exactly 1 minute, stirring.
- 3 Remove from heat. Stir in peanut butter and vanilla, then quickly stir in oats.
- 4 Drop spoonfuls onto parchment and let set 20-30 minutes. Keep children away from the hot sugar mixture.

KID HELPER

After the mixture cools slightly, the kids can help choose where the finished cookies go.

LEFTOVERS

Store airtight at room temperature 4 days.



D5

Cookies &
Desserts

Fudgy Brownies

Prep 10 min | Cook 25 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Mixing bowl, 8x8 pan, whisk

INGREDIENTS

- 1/2 cup melted butter
- 1 cup sugar
- 2 eggs
- 1 tsp vanilla
- 1/3 cup cocoa powder
- 1/2 cup flour
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1/2 cup chocolate chips, optional

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Heat oven to 350 F. Grease or line an 8x8-inch pan.
- 2 Whisk melted butter and sugar, then whisk in eggs and vanilla.
- 3 Stir in cocoa, flour and salt just until combined; fold in chips if using.
- 4 Spread in pan and bake 20-25 minutes. A toothpick should have moist crumbs, not wet batter. Cool before cutting.

KID HELPER The kids can whisk the dry ingredients or add chocolate chips.

LEFTOVERS Cover and keep 4 days; brownies also freeze well.



D6

Cookies &
Desserts

Easy Apple Crisp

Prep 20 min | Cook 40 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Knife, 9x13 dish, mixing bowl

INGREDIENTS

- 6 apples
- 1 tbsp lemon juice
- 1 tsp cinnamon
- 1/2 cup sugar
- 1 cup old-fashioned oats
- 3/4 cup flour
- 3/4 cup brown sugar
- 1/2 cup melted butter

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Heat oven to 375 F. Peel apples if desired, slice thinly and place in a greased baking dish.
- 2 Toss apples with lemon juice, cinnamon and sugar.
- 3 Mix oats, flour, brown sugar and melted butter until crumbly; sprinkle over apples.
- 4 Bake 35-45 minutes until bubbling and golden. Cool 10 minutes before serving.

KID HELPER

The kids can mix and sprinkle the oat topping.

LEFTOVERS

Refrigerate covered up to 4 days and reheat gently.



D7

Cookies &
Desserts

Marshmallow Cereal Treats

Prep 10 min | Cook 10 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Large pot, spatula, 9x13 pan

INGREDIENTS

- 6 tbsp butter
- 10 oz marshmallows
- 6 cups crisp rice cereal
- Pinch of salt
- Nonstick spray or extra butter

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Lightly grease a 9x13-inch pan and a spatula.
- 2 Melt butter in a large pot over low heat. Add marshmallows and stir until smooth.
- 3 Remove from heat, stir in salt and cereal until evenly coated.
- 4 Press gently into the pan without packing hard. Cool 30 minutes before cutting.

KID HELPER

After an adult handles the hot mixture, the kids can help press it with a greased spatula.

LEFTOVERS

Keep airtight at room temperature up to 3 days.



D8

Cookies &
Desserts

Easy Chocolate Pudding Pie

Prep 15 min | Cook 0 min | Serves 4 | Easy | \$

PREP & TOOLS

Mixing bowl, whisk, refrigerator

INGREDIENTS

- 1 prepared graham cracker crust
- 2 boxes instant chocolate pudding, about 3.9 oz each
- 3 cups cold milk
- 8 oz whipped topping
- Chocolate shavings, optional

DIRECTIONS

- 1 Whisk pudding mix and cold milk for 2 minutes until thickened.
- 2 Fold half the whipped topping gently into the pudding.
- 3 Spoon filling into the crust and smooth the top.
- 4 Refrigerate at least 4 hours. Top with remaining whipped topping before serving.

KID HELPER

The kids can whisk the pudding and help spread whipped topping.

LEFTOVERS

Keep refrigerated and eat within 3 days.

Cooking safety

Use an instant-read thermometer in the thickest part of the food. Color alone is not a reliable doneness test.

Food	Minimum temperature	Rest
Chicken and other poultry	165 F	None required
Ground beef, pork or turkey	160 F	None required
Steak and pork chops	145 F	3 minutes
Leftovers	165 F	None required

Source: FoodSafety.gov - Safe Minimum Internal Temperatures

<https://www.foodsafety.gov/food-safety-charts/safe-minimum-internal-temperatures>

What to send me

Choose any 2-5 meal cards and, if wanted, add a D-code dessert. Example: B1, C3, P2, F5 and D1. Tell me whether the optional \$50 is available. I will handle the combined shopping list, quantities, ingredient overlap, storage plan and cooking order.